North York Recipe for Healing: Community-Based Digital Storytelling Archive

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Food is connected with individuals' cultural identities and lived experiences. Food studies scholars established that recipes can be analyzed as an embodiment of information to reveal knowledge about their producers and users (Leonardi, 1989; Cotter, 1997; Tippen, 2014; Mihalache, 2018). The local knowledge risks being lost if not documented in ways accessible to the community. "North York Recipes for Healing" (2023) is an open-access online archive of oral history co-created with East Asian immigrants in North York, Toronto, Canada. Through recipe sharing and storytelling, the project looked into migration, identity formation and community building, as well as more recent issues with food insecurity and Anti-Asian racism during the COVID-19 pandemic.

Oral history interview as a method prioritizes individuals' lived experiences and directly involves non-academics in knowledge contributions (Levkoe, 2015; Hasselberg & Amilien, 2024). The 15 interviews were then curated and presented in an online archive through ArcGIS Story map for public access, encouraging the community to heal together through sharing culinary knowledge and stories. In order to continue the working relationship and expand on the community impact, a series of engagement events were organized as continuity of the digital archive, including library talks, traditional holiday celebrations, and food tours.

The presentation will emphasize the potential of using food as a lens to build public archives with direct community involvement. The research shows that adapting and changing recipes is a common practice among immigrants, which can be used as a pivot point to encourage community storytelling. Recipe adaptation led to discussions in which culinary innovation is seen as a method for personal expression of cultural identities, a tool for community building, and a way to create a sense of belonging. This finding could guide further investigation of the significance of recipe adaption in immigrant history, and its potential to empower future innovation.

In addition to sharing the research findings, the presenter reflected on the experience of working with community members to create this digital archive. The challenges include the effort to involve multigenerational conversation, in which the senior members of the community face language and technical barriers; and the long process to gain trust and build a relationship with the community while working under a one-year contract timeline. The presentation will analyze the challenges and solutions under Morse's (2021) framework, where she approaches community-centred museum practices through the notion of care. Conducting community-based research is both a rewarding and challenging process. The project provides two key learnings in research design: 1) Benefits to the community: It was a time-consuming process to gain trust and establish relationships with the community, especially with food business owners who are occupied with daily operations and don't see much value in academic research. 2) Scope: It was also difficult to capture the diversity within the community with a limited sample size and increasing the level of specificity in research design is helpful in avoiding misrepresentation and overgeneration.

Through "North York Recipe for Healing", the presenter aims to share research findings, reflect on the challenges and learnings in community co-creation projects in a digital age, and provide suggestions and directions for future work.

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